Very soon, differences arose between Longowal and Bhindranwale over the nature and scope of the morcha. Bhindranwale wanted to target the Central government but Longowal was opposed to that. The Akalis realized that Bhindranwale's style of functioning as well as his approach were dangerous to their cause. But they did not have the courage to take a stand against him openly. In order to remain relevant to the Punjab scene and retain their support among the Sikhs, the Akali Dal leadership were being forced to adopt a more aggressive stance on various issues, which they actually did not like. Worried that Bhidranwale would highjack their peaceful programme, the Akalis decided that their next programme would be announced from the Golden Temple on
4 November 1982.

It was mainly due to the predicament the Akalis found themselves in vis-à-vis Bhindranwale that Longowal sent a personal messenger to Sardar Swaran Singh sometime towards the end of September 1982, seeking his help in getting them out of the sticky situation they were in. They wanted Swaran Singh to use his well-known negotiating skills to work out a face-saving formula, which could help them withdraw their morcha and in turn build pressure on Bhindranwale to leave the Golden Temple complex and return to his gurudwara at Chowk Mehta.

Swaran Singh's intervention

After getting his M.Sc. Physics and law degrees from Punjab University, Lahore, and after a brief stint as lecturer in Lyallpur Khalsa College, Jalandhar, Swaran Singh joined Khizr Hayat Khan's cabinet in Punjab in 1946 as food and civil supplies minister. Post-Independence, he served as home minister in Gopi Chand Bhargava's cabinet in Punjab. After practising law for three years (1949–1952) at Punjab High Court, he joined Bhimsen Sachar's cabinet in 1952 as minister in charge of capital projects and electricity. Soon after that, on Prime Minister Nehru's invitation, he joined the Union cabinet as works, housing and supplies minister